

Knoppix 5.0.1

If one happens to use and appreciate Live Linux CD's then the accolades should go to Knoppix, because it was the first distro to pullout the so called 'Live-CD' rabbit out of the hat.

Installation

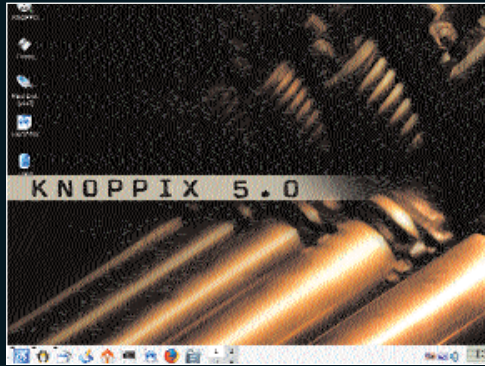
There is no installation required to run Knoppix. Just pop the CD/DVD in your drive and you will have a complete Linux Operating system running in about five minutes. We downloaded the 3.5 GB DVD version and it came packed to the gills with more software than you'll ever need. The Knoppix 5 version was released in CeBIT this year and it offers features like no other Live CD distro.

Most live CD's load the required files into the memory to run, hence generally speaking the higher the amount of memory you have the more responsive the Live CD will be. Since both our test machine were configured with 1 GB of memory, Knoppix was cruising. On machines with 512 MB and less memory, the response times took a hit.

Desktop and Application

Once the DVD boots it defaults to KDE desktop, after seeing Gnome 2.14 in action, we have begun liking the minimalist approach it has; nevertheless Knoppix offers the essential things right up front.

Due to the DVD version we used the menu structure was too long—but that's understandable, it was cramped with application we have never heard off. In case you plan to use



The Best way to try everything in Linux

Knoppix we suggest you download the CD version and not the DVD version; the DVD has just too much stuff on it.

What's really good about Knoppix that we like is that it auto-mounts hard drive partition and makes them available on the desktop. If your Windows machine goes down, this Live CD comes handy—we vouch for it, helped us on numerous counts. Similarly, external devices such as USB drives, external hard drives, digital cameras, etc., were also promptly detected.

Verdict

Hands down the best Live CD Linux distro available! We recommend you to keep a copy of Knoppix, for one day it will definitely come handy.



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Applications

One good thing about any Linux distribution is the applications that come with it. While distributions such as SuSE, Fedora Core 5, Mandriva and Xandros take a “more the merrier” approach; Ubuntu believes in the essentials.

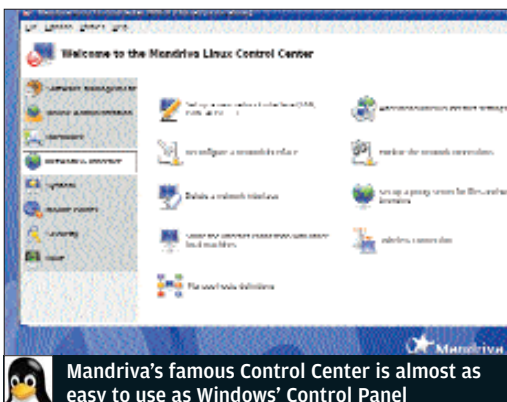
Ubuntu 6.06 is a single-CD distribution and makes the most of the space by providing essential applications only. This might be a good strategy—keep the clutter to a minimum and not intimidate a beginner with too many choices. However, adding extra applications to Ubuntu means a fast Internet connection becomes a must—a scarce commodity in India. Neverthe-

less, the bundled applications are enough for a typical desktop usage. Ubuntu came bundled with the new Gnome 2.14 desktop environment, OpenOffice.Org 2.02, Firefox as the default browser, GIMP 2.2 for image manipulation, Evolution as the e-mail client, GAIM 1.51 for instant messaging and Totem video player. Sadly, proprietary audio/video formats are not supported, but that can be resolved by simply installing Mplayer. One can also install scripts such as Automatix, which automatically installs all the required third party codecs to make the box multimedia compliant.

We still remember when the SuSE 6.2 box landed in our Lab some five years ago—not for the green box, but for the bundle. Some five CD's and two huge comprehensive installation manuals. And the tradition is still intact; **SuSE 10** is a five CD distro containing hundreds of applications that most people will never require for standard desktop usage.

The package includes Firefox 1.5 for browsing, Evolution for e-mails and contact management, Helix Banshee music player, F-Spot photo browser (looks similar to Google's Picasa) and OpenOffice.org 2.0 for word processing. While these might be the regular applications, there are some applications that are unique to SuSE.

Novell, the network company that took over



Mandriva's famous Control Center is almost as easy to use as Windows' Control Panel